

The Lie

“Eyes up, Guardian!”

The voice that greeted my ears sounded as though it were filtered through whirring mechanisms and muffled by an iron mask. I blinked, still groggy from my slumber. How long had I been asleep? Actually, when did I fall asleep? The last thing I remembered was...

There was no last thing I remembered. My eyes shot open wide, realization jolting through me like a plunge into Arctic waters. I *knew* things—things I couldn’t explain how I knew. I knew what color the sky was supposed to be on a myriad of worlds. I knew what sounds the birds made on a cool Spring morning, what the bold taste of coffee was like, and what the language this creature was speaking to me meant. What I didn’t know was what *it* was.

Floating in the air, just a few feet from me, was a small, mechanical creature. It was slightly larger than my hand, which seemed somehow large to me, and it was made of several whirring pieces of metal. The light at the center of its... face? It seemed to be looking me up and down, as though it were an eye. Then, it narrowed and lifted itself, as though it were... trying to smile at me, though it had no discernable mouth.

“I’m so glad I found you! I’ve been searching for so long, I was beginning to give up hope. The other Ghosts told me that searching for you here was a long shot, but I was determined to search *everywhere*. Even if the odds were... *astronomically low*.” The creature once again smiled at me and let out what I can only assume was a laugh. I wasn’t quite sure what was funny about that, but I had bigger questions to ask.

“Who... are you? *What* are you?”

“Oh, *heavens* me!” It chuckled again. “My name is Meta! I’m a Ghost—more specifically, I’m *your* Ghost.”

“A ghost? So does that mean I’m dead? And you’re part of me?” I wasn’t quite sure what to make of this creature, but if he was part of me, and I had died, it might explain the memory loss. Maybe he was the part of me with the memories.

“Well, yes. And no. Or rather, flip that. I’m a Ghost—a living creature created by the Traveler! And yes, you did die—a long time ago. The Traveler gave me a mission: to find a suitable person from humanity’s past, that I could bring back to become a Guardian! Your job is to protect humanity in the Traveler’s stead. And I? I will be your partner. Together, we can use the Light of the Traveler to fight back against the enemies of humanity. Whenever you get hurt, whenever you struggle—I’ll be right there beside you to pick you back up.”

“What do you mean by ‘the enemies of humanity’? And why did you say finding me here was unlikely?”

“Well, the first part is a complicated matter; I’ll explain that over time. As for the latter—well, I suppose it wasn’t *finding* you that was the hard part. It was finding enough of you to bring back, and

then helping you get to the City intact. The other Ghosts thought that I was a bit... *loony*. But what can I say? I knew, when I found you, that I'd be *over the moon!*" Meta broke off into a cackling fit. I looked at him quizzically.

"Why do you keep doing that?" The Ghost looked up at me.

"Haven't you noticed yet? It's not night." He looked up to the black sky. Far above, in the distance, was the Earth, glistening with beauty and potential.

"Like I said—" he gestured towards the gray, dusty ground I was sitting on. "I'm *over the Moon*."

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Over the following days and weeks, Meta taught me what it meant to be a Guardian. He gave me a breakdown of the different enemies I'd encounter, what to expect when we made it to the City, and so much more. Once, he'd even sprung a surprise gift on me—a cloak. Joking that I was the most Hunter a Titan he'd ever seen—or maybe the other way around—he told me I'd probably need to pick a class once we got to the City, so one of the Vanguard could assign another Guardian to train me. Meta said he'd back any choice I made, though he couldn't picture me in a dress. He'd laughed at that; I almost smiled.

Unfortunately, life on the Moon wasn't as idyllic as it was during the Golden Age. There was no easy way back to Earth, and unlike a Ghost, I couldn't just fly my way back home. While we were stuck there, trying to find a way to Earth, we spent a lot of time familiarizing ourselves with our neighbors, the Hive. The Moon was theirs more than it was ours. Meta helped me scrape up resources and run ops against them, from small scouting missions to stealthy disruption missions. Heck, he even found a few opportunities to take out some high-value targets. My abnormally large size made me a surprisingly good match against even some of the Hive Knights, though they were still a head taller than me. The times we bit off more than I could chew, Meta always managed to bail me out.

It was around six weeks into our routine when Meta came up to me with another op. It was pretty standard—a Wizard was running a ritual, and I had a chance to disrupt it. Meta had scouted it out, and said security seemed light. With any luck, I could even take out the Wizard. Every little bit could help, he said. It'd be easy, he said.

By the time we arrived at the ritual site—a grand room that doubled as one of the many entrances to the intricate tunnel system the Hive were digging into the Moon—the ritual was well underway. I wasn't sure exactly what was going on, but we were watching the Wizard from an alcove above when things went south. The Wizard stopped mid-ritual, and Hive magic burst into a cage around us. It was a trap; they'd known we would come. I frantically turned around, ready to break free from the cage, when I saw it. The grinning skull-face of a Hive Knight. Its blade fell with a resounding slam.

A massive force blew me backwards, away from the Knight—who'd been thrown in the opposite direction. The room briefly flashed with light. As I tried to catch my breath, I realized it hadn't been knocked out of me. I felt... hollow. Like something was missing. Some vital part of me had been ripped out. And then I saw it. The Knight hadn't missed me; the shattered pieces of Meta scattered across the floor in front of me proved that I hadn't been the target at all.

Something else began to fill that void within me. Fury embroiled me. Unarmed, I tried to reach for my gun, to the space where Meta had always kept it—and found nothing still. The Knight stirred across from me. Its blade had been knocked from its hand when Meta had died. The rage took over as I reached for the last gift my partner had given me. Hands wrapped around the Cleaver, I made my own fate.

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I'm not sure how long I spent on the Moon—months, maybe even years passed without distinction. Without Meta, I had no hope of finding a way to Earth. In those times, I did what I could to honor his memory. Armed with the Cleaver I'd claimed that day, I continued running ops against the Hive.

Unlike before, I could no longer rely on my Ghost to bail me out of a bad situation. Instead, I'd thrown myself at the Hive with complete conviction. Either I would die doing as much damage as I could, or I would return victorious. The resolve I found assured my blade; the confidence I built pushed me to tackle any challenge I could. I learned to speak as the Hive did, that I might grasp their schemes. I learned their lore, tackling tomes I procured during raids. I even learned to manipulate their magics—enough to turn their rituals against them with all the finesse of a bull; that is, my subtlety with their magic matched the subtlety of my blade.

It was on another standard op that I encountered something that gave me hope. I'd found that the Hive were preparing—and even sending—Seeder ships to Earth. While this made sense—the Moon was an ideal staging ground for an invasion of Earth—it surprised me that I hadn't discovered this previously. If I could get on a ship... maybe I could somehow make it to the City. Maybe I wouldn't be alone. Maybe... I could live up to Meta's hopes for me.

Sneaking onto a Seeder was a difficult endeavor—especially after I got caught the first time. I managed to fight my way out, but they began adding more guards. And, even if I could get through by force, I'd seen the controls. There was no way I could fly one myself. Sneaking aboard was my only option—and I'd have to make sure the one I was on was actually heading to Earth.

That was when I met her.

I don't know who she was. I knew *what* she was—a Hive Wizard, adorned in unusual garb compared to the other Hive I'd seen. It wasn't that she was of a higher or lower rank—the symbols she wore denoted her as belonging to... something different. Either this Wizard's job was completely different from any other I'd encountered, or she was devoted to a different brood entirely.

I'd been resting in my camp; I moved around nearly every day, like Meta had taught me, but I still needed to take breaks and rest. Suddenly, I'd heard a raspy voice behind me, speaking in a broken version of the same language Meta and I had used.

"*You are... Lightbearer?*" I whirled around, hand on my sword immediately. In response, the Wizard lifted her hands in surrender and settled herself on the ground—both acts that seemed unnatural to me. My curiosity stayed my blade.

"No, but I am aligned with them. What does it matter?" It had been so long since I'd spoken—much less in this language—that I wasn't sure she would understand what I meant.

"I bring... gift. Go with me. I... help." My instincts screamed not to trust her; my mind, however, told a different story. This Wizard had snuck up on me while I was resting. It would have been easy to slay me, had she wished. She could have killed me herself, or trapped me and summoned reinforcements. No, whatever she was planning, it went beyond killing me. And, besides that, I felt that gnawing curiosity, telling me to follow her, to see what she had. Perhaps there was more Warlock in me than even Meta had known. I gripped my sword.

"Lead the way."

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She led me down towards the Seeder ships. She carefully wove us between patrols until eventually, we reached a ship being loaded for departure. Motioning me to stay hidden behind a crate, she gave me a nod and moved towards the guards in front of the ship—a pair of Knights. From where I was, I could hear her speaking in Krill to them—or at least, I could hear enough.

She was telling them that she'd found the rogue Guardian.

She needed their help to pin me down and take me out. I froze, the rage rising within me. It had truly all been a ploy, just some scheme to make it easier to kill me. I thought back to all the patrols we'd passed on the way here—I was sandwiched. There was no way I could fight through a small army like that. This was the end. I heard the pair of guards running my way. Gripping my sword, I prepared to fight them all.

And then they passed.

I stared in confusion. The Knights were running back out the way we'd came. The Wizard came floating around the crate beside me and gestured to me to run—*quickly*. She led me into the loading bay and behind some crates, then she stacked another on top to cover me. As she began to float away, I called out to her in Krill, keeping my voice as low as possible.

"Why are you helping me?" By this point, I couldn't see her, but her voice was still audible.

*"The Hive are not as unified as you may believe."* It wasn't much of an explanation—there had to be more. But her words echoed through my mind all the way to Earth.

When the ship finally settled down, I could see the faint glow of sunlight beaming into the loading bay and the blue of the sky peeking over a crate. In the distance, I heard a sound—one I hadn't heard since I'd become Risen—the sound of birds chirping. Against all odds, I'd made it one step closer.

*Meta, I thought. I will make you proud.*